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Section Title(S): THE HOMONYMOUS METHOD

3. The !Kung have no surnames.

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Personal Names

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Naming
4. Names are sex-linked; hence men and women never have the same name.

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Personal Names

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Naming
5. According to !Kung kinship regulations, parents and child must not bear the same name. The !Kung said it would be “madness” for a man to name a son for himself or a daughter for her mother. In gathering genealogical data, I encountered no deviation from this rule.

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6. Children are always named for relatives, either consanguineous or affinal. They are named for relatives in the first or second ascending generation. The relatives may be living or dead. The father may or may not have the joking relationship with the relative for whom he names his child.

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7. A man invariably names his firstborn son for his father (i.e., the child's FaFa) and his firstborn daughter for his mother (the child's FaMo). If he has more than one wife, he names the firstborn son and daughter of each wife for his father and mother respectively. Thus half siblings, though they are not named for each other, often bear the same name, having been named for the same person. I believe that the !Kung adhere strictly to this rule. When in the band charts the oldest son or daughter to appear does not bear the FaFa's or FaMo's name, it may be assumed that a child who did bear that name has previously died. My records of dead children are not complete. Sometimes when a firstborn child dies, the father gives his father's or mother's name to the next son or daughter born, but this is not required by the rule.⁶

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A man often, but not invariably, names his secondborn son for the child's MoFa and secondborn daughter for her MoMo. Fifty-one percent of the !Kung in my records are named for their grandparents.⁷ Subsequent 225 children, I was told, are usually named for the siblings of their father or mother, or for the spouses of those siblings. These are the usual namings, but children may be named for other relatives: I know of two children, for example, named for their parents' cousins. It is not their custom, !Kung informants told me, to name children for the children's great-grandparents or for the siblings of the children's grandparents. However, this last custom is not observed with fidelity: I know of at least one child named for his grandmother's younger brother. There may be more. My genealogical records are not full enough with respect to the dead for me to trace every naming.

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6. An example: the mother of Gao Beard is Old Xama. Gao gave her name to his first daughter by his first wife (a child who died), to his second daughter by his first wife, and to his first daughter by his second wife. Both his wives, incidentally, are named//Kushay.

7. We wondered if *!gun!a* came into the system with the homonymous method and speculated that perhaps it originally used to be applied only to the person for whom ego is named. It is not strictly a kinship term, being composed of translatable words, "big or old name." We think it may have been superimposed upon *tūn!ga* (which probably comes from the same root as *tūn*). *Tūn!ga* may originally have been applied to grandfather, man-speaking as well as woman-speaking, and later *!gun!a* may have become associated with grandfather because so many men are named for their grandfathers. Megan Bieseke, who has great mastery of the !Kung language, has assured me that the "u" in *tūn!ga* is nasalized, whereas I had been uncertain myself. I have added the tilde.

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